Cat's in the Cradle and Love You Forever

By Harry Chapin and Robert Munsch

INTRODUCTION

For a couple of hundred years now, each generation of fathers has passed on less and less to their sons--not just less power, but less wisdom. And less love. Today, we've reached a point where many fathers are largely irrelevant in the lives of their children.

Harry Chapin's hit lyrical poem "Cat's in the Cradle" is about an overly-absent father. Time passes, with other responsibilities always taking precedence over his child, until suddenly the child is grown, minus the influence of his father. Ironically, Harry Chapin died in a car accident in 1981 and never got to see his own children grown up . . . making this poem somehow even sadder.

This compilation combines Cat's in the Cradle by Harry Chapin and Love You Forever by Robert Munsch . . . to remind both parents and children that it's never too late to love.

Cat's in the Cradle by Harry Chapin

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My child arrived just the other day
He came to the world in the usual way
But there were planes to catch and bills to pay
He learned to walk while I was away
And he was talkin' 'fore I knew it, and as he grew
He'd say "I'm gonna be like you dad
You know I'm gonna be like you"

And the cat's in the cradle and the silver spoon
Little boy blue and the man on the moon
When you comin' home dad?
I don't know when, but we'll get together then son
You know we'll have a good time then

My son turned ten just the other day
He said, "Thanks for the ball, Dad, come on let's play
Can you teach me to throw", I said "Not today
I got a lot to do", he said, "That's ok"
And he walked away but his smile never dimmed
And said, "I'm gonna be like him, yeah
You know I'm gonna be like him"

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And the cat's in the cradle and the silver spoon
Little boy blue and the man on the moon
When you comin' home son?
I don't know when, but we'll get together then son
You know we'll have a good time then

Well, he came home from college just the other day
So much like a man I just had to say
"Son, I'm proud of you, can you sit for a while?"
He shook his head and said with a smile
"What I'd really like, Dad, is to borrow the car keys
See you later, can I have them please?"

And the cat's in the cradle and the silver spoon
Little boy blue and the man on the moon
When you comin' home son?
I don't know when, but we'll get together then son
You know we'll have a good time then

I've long since retired, my son's moved away
I called him up just the other day

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I said, "I'd like to see you if you don't mind"
He said, "I'd love to, Dad, if I can find the time
You see my new job's a hassle and kids have the flu
But it's sure nice talking to you, Dad
It's been sure nice talking to you"

And as I hung up the phone it occurred to me
He'd grown up just like me
My boy was just like me

And the cat's in the cradle and the silver spoon
Little boy blue and the man on the moon
When you comin' home son?
I don't know when, but we'll get together then son
You know we'll have a good time then

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Harry Chapin
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TRANSITION

Love You Forever started as a song that Robert Munch made up to comfort himself while he and his wife grieved the stillborn death of two children. Every time he sang it to himself, he cried for the loss of those two children he would never hold . . . never see grow up. In this poem, we learn so much about the circle of life, about youth, about parenting and about our own responsibilities to our children and to our parents as they get older. Love You Forever by Robert Munsch

A mother held her new baby
and very slowly rocked him back and forth,
back and forth, back and forth.
And while she held him, she sang:

I'll love you forever,
I'll like you for always,
As long as I'm living
my baby you'll be.

The baby grew.
He grew and he grew and he grew.
He grew until he was two years old,
and he ran all around the house.

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He pulled all the books off the shelves.
He pulled all the food out of the refrigerator
and he took his mother's watch and
flushed it down the toilet.
Sometimes his mother would say,
"This kid is driving me CRAZY!"

But at night time,
when that two-year-old was quiet,
she opened the door to his room,
crawled across the floor,
looked up over the side of his bed;
and if he was really asleep
she picked him up and rocked him back and forth,
back and forth, back and forth.
While she rocked him she sang:

I'll love you forever,
I'll like you for always,
As long as I'm living
my baby you'll be.

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The little boy grew.
He grew and he grew and he grew.
He grew until he was nine years old.
And he never wanted to come in for dinner,
he never wanted to take a bath,
and when grandma visited he always said bad words.
Sometimes his mother wanted to sell him to the zoo!

But at night time,
when he was asleep,
the mother quietly opened the door to his room,
crawled across the floor
and looked up over the side of the bed.
If he was really asleep,
she picked up that nine-year-old boy
and rocked him back and forth,
back and forth, back and forth.
And while she rocked him she sang:

I'll love you forever,
I'll like you for always,

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As long as I'm living
my baby you'll be.

The boy grew.
He grew and he grew and he grew.
He grew until he was a teenager.
He had strange friends
and he wore strange clothes
and he listened to strange music.
Sometimes the mother felt like she was in a zoo!

But at night time,
when that teenager was asleep,
the mother opened the door to his room,
crawled across the floor
and looked up over the side of the bed.
If he was really asleep she picked up that great big boy
and rocked him back and forth,
back and forth, back and forth.
While she rocked him she sang:

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I'll love you forever,
I'll like you for always,
As long as I'm living
my baby you'll be.

That teenager grew.
He grew and he grew and he grew.
He grew until he was a grown-up man.
He left home and got a house across town.
But sometimes on dark nights
the mother got into her car and drove across town.
If all the lights in her son's house were out,
she opened his bedroom window,
crawled across the floor,
and looked up over the side of his bed.
If that great big man was really asleep
she picked him up and rocked him back and forth,
back and forth, back and forth.
And while she rocked him she sang:

I'll love you forever,
I'll like you for always,

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As long as I'm living
my baby you'll be.

Well, that mother, she got older.
She got older and older and older.
One day she called up her son and said,
"You'd better come see me
because I'm very old and sick."
So her son came to see her.
When he came in the door she tried to sing the song.
She sang:

I'll love you forever,
I'll like you for always...

But she couldn't finish
because she was too old and sick.
The son went to his mother.
He picked her up and rocked her back and forth,
back and forth, back and forth.
And he sang this song:

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I'll love you forever,

I'll like you for always,

As long as I'm living

my Mommy you'll be.

When the son came home that night,

he stood for a long time at the top of the stairs.

Then he went into the room

where his very new baby daughter was sleeping.

He picked her up in his arms

and very slowly rocked her back and forth,

back and forth, back and forth.

And while he rocked her he sang:

I'll love you forever,

I'll like you for always,

As long as I'm living

my baby you'll be.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Robert Munsch
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